Times are tough. We trail 2–1 in the series, with only the fifth and final Test to be played at Centurion, and I am feeling the pressure. Called up as a 20-year-old stroke-player, for all my energy and efforts in the field, I have been moved around the order and produced underwhelming scores of 28, 14, 14, 52*, 21, 10, 19 and 3. It's not good enough and I sense that more low scores at SuperSport Park will result in me being dropped.

Have I ever been so nervous?

I don't think so.

The first day is rained out, but my parents and brothers are watching on the second morning as Michael Vaughan wins the toss and decides to field. I am told I will open the innings with Herschelle, with Graeme batting lower down at five. That's fine with me because I enjoy the new ball coming on to the bat. This is sink or swim and, in tough batting conditions, I manage to swim, working hard to reach 50 and then moving into the 90s.

Ashley Giles, the left-arm spinner, is bowling accurately. I thrive until I am eight runs from completing my first Test century, but I am impatient to reach the landmark and decide to execute a lap sweep for four. The foolish premeditation proves fatal. I'm struck on the pad, the English voices are appealing again and I am out, LBW for 92.

We scramble to 247 all out, which is about par on a tricky two-paced pitch, and England make 359 in reply, taking time out of the game and making it difficult for us to force a win and square the series. We lose two quick wickets in our second innings and, on the back foot and unavoidably focused on surviving when we are really looking for an opportunity to attack and win, Jacques Kallis and I come together at 29 for two.

I start to settle, still feeling as if I am batting to save my place, and, increasingly confident batting in my home ground, start to build a partnership with Jacques. Runs start to flow from my two favourite shots – the square cut to anything fractionally short on or outside the off stump, slashed away past point, and the slog pull to mid-wicket off